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Cecil McBee

Bassist and composer Cecil McBee has played a vital role in multiple genres of jazz since 1964. He has recorded with a lengthy list of artists that include Alice Coltrane, Pharoah Sanders, and Charles Lloyd.

He was interviewed on November 6, 2020 via Zoom, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College, and it's a privilege today to speak with bassist, composer, and music educator Cecil McBee, who is in Brooklyn and I am in Clinton, New York. And thank you for joining me, Mr. McBee.

CM: Thank you for joining me and having me realized here.

MR: Yeah. I thought it would be worthwhile to put our conversation in a bit of context for people who may watch this down the road, that it is November 6, 2020 and we have just had a presidential election which may be decided while we're talking. We're in the midst of a pandemic and climate change, and significant social unrest. So my first question is, it could be a hard one, but I wonder in your lifetime do you remember a more turbulent era? A more turbulent period, than in current times?

CM: No, but close was the Civil Rights Movement in the late 60s, measurably that was something that would parallel this one. But this one was rather commanding for all of us with the realization that the democracy probably could find itself on its knees questioning whether or not it will continue. And that's been rather scary. Being a person of this country one would never think that we'd come that close to losing who we are so far as our standing locally, collectively, and in the world as a democracy, with the constitution being seriously challenged. It's been rather scary. And you know, being that you are who you are and so forth, what your livelihood is, mine being music, even that can be, has been rather touched, you know, your spirit, your desire to perform and to play, but measurably what does that mean and so forth, who you will be down the road. And what audiences are capable of continuing or realizing who you are or what your intent is to express. All that would come to mind. But of course the music would continue, but I guess I should say that my responsibility would be perhaps individually and collectively if you will, to rise up and let the music, you know, be a healing kind of quality that might help along the way. But I don't think we'll have to go through that now. It looks like the percentages now, the outcome of the election will be seeming to be favorable. So I'm relaxing a bit. A little.

MR: Yes, me too.

MR: You were in the middle of some very creative music during the Civil Rights Era. Have you seen, in the last few years, a similar path by musicians to create music that expresses emotions about the times as you did back in the 60s?

CM: That's a good question. That has waned a bit. And in my world of thought, actually I've been rather critical of that expected continuum if you will, because it seems that things, the creativity and intent to express continual to become new are individually realized, I guess the individual, I tell my students that if you want to find something new, if you want to really discover what is happening, if you develop your crafts individual to yourself, that's what's new. You know, whoever you are. That's what's new if you become yourself that's what's new because nobody's going to play like you, perform like you. I've seen little of that. I've seen a cessation of that quality of thought, in my estimation, around the world. It's that the same music that brought me about, and brought others about and so forth, some kind of acclaim, is still being played for the most part. And the only opportunity that I have to experience something brand new, or something that we continue that would maintain the reach for other things, is in my classroom at the school, at the New England Conservatory. Young people are really thinking. I've got a couple of young composers in performance that are beyond me when I was 19, 20, when I first began. These guys are really, you know, reaching out past the outer edges into their own realm of newness. And I'm very, very excited about that. But they are few and far between. They're not on the stage yet. So I don't get a lot from us older guys that have been around in that regard except for like playing beautifully and wonderfully who you are at this particular time.

MR: Well as you said, your older guys who have been around, when you moved to New York in 1964, I think I'm correct about that, I'm going to guess that as a jazz musician you had to do a certain amount of scrambling, reaching out to other people, finding a mentor, and making connections. Isn't that part of finding out who you are, forming your personality. And I wonder if young people don't have that opportunity now?

CM: Young people don't have a lot of that kind of opportunity, but as far as I'm concerned, when I arrived in New York City I needed not a sound. I had no need for a mentor. I had no need to discover myself. I had, although having not researched who was doing what at what level, etcetera, etcetera. I had studied. I wanted to be a music teacher. So I finished college before arriving in New York and I tell everybody that in college I flunked everything but I was a great student in the music area. And so when I arrived in New York City I was very, very abreast of what music was. I studied the classics, Bach, Beethoven, you know, Stravinsky etcetera, etcetera, Schoenberg. Paul Chambers was my greatest mentor so far as being in, as a young guy in need of some kind of guidance —

instrument, I mean I was in the Army before I finished college, in the band, as a clarinetist. And when the band practices were finished, for two years, I would practice my bass throughout the waning, the late hours of the evening, on and on. You know I had this inspiration to develop my personal reality. So doing that for two years, then returning to college, finishing, graduating with a degree in music education, when I arrived in New York City I felt I had something on my shoulder. And upon listening to those around me, with the exception of a few, I mean I felt very competitive if you will. Because I heard a lot of it all. I felt rather comfortable with myself as one who would express at my expected level of competence. And that happened. Because the moment I arrived in New York City, my first record was with Grachan Moncur III called "Some Other Stuff" which featured Herbie Hancock, Wayne Shorter and Tony Williams. And then I went from there to Jackie McLean, and then I went from there to Charles Lloyd. You know, and I'm just arriving in New York. So I felt pretty good about my entrance into the city.

MR: Well that sort of addressed a question I had in mind because I was reading through your discography and the list of all the people that you've played with and who have played with you as a leader, and I'm curious why you were chosen so often, why were you the bass player of choice so many hundreds of times?

CM: Well let me put it this way: I'm my worst, I've been over the years, my worst critic. It continued. Until recently I never could appreciate what I've done. There's always more and more that I could learn. And I don't see that romantically, that's realistic, you know, reality and so forth. But last summer my wife, knowing that I would return from the Conservatory at Boston at about 7:00, when I walked in there was this record going. And I said, "Wow, who is the bass player? If I could play like that, that's where I really want to be." She said, "That's you back in 1977" with Yusef Lateef or somebody. So as an individual, simply all this says is that I'm sort of a romantic you know. Music is my reason to be. It's my therapy. It's my means to define myself as someone at this particular point of time that would create at a level that would allow me to realize even more where all that's about, and appreciating that which would impact upon me.

MR: Nice. Well speaking of recognizing yourself and going back in your career, I came across an article that a critic, you performed at the Carnegie Hall in 1984 with Chico Freeman, just a duet.

CM: Yeah, I remember that.

MR: And this is what John Pareles, part of what he said about you: "Mr. McBee makes the bass sing out clearly in every register and at any volume, even a whisper. He reaffirmed that only a handful of bassists can match his technique. He can also make virtually any tempo swing." Nice.

CM: A great honor to that — wow. Like I just expressed, I'm one, you know, when having first arrived in New York, simply wants to express myself. I felt very privileged to play the instrument at whatever intent I had, because I had to realize the realization of the quality of my talent. It was just happening and I was happy to be on the stage and just play my butt off and have a good time. So that was a moment when that was happening. And if I remember that moment it was like I'm at Carnegie Hall, now I'm a little shy, you know? And I didn't feel that I was playing up to my level but normally, you know, you — well I finally realized that whoever you are at the moment so long as you play that regardless, it can be appreciated. So at that moment it's good to get evaluated well.

MR: Yeah. I wonder if you had had a recording experience where for whatever reason you weren't quite comfortable with the leader's concept musically, spiritually or otherwise, that you didn't really feel that you fit in with where this music, what this music was trying to accomplish.

CM: Well no and yes. I, as mentioned before, my intent has always been to express regardless. It's just like getting, you know, something from myself that would better myself as having engaged myself in something, again, like Roy Haynes said, "Music is my therapy." And so, but there have been moments where I have struggled because of the inability to fashion certain qualities of intent on the instrument. For instance, driving back to New York from Boston the other day, I teach there on Mondays and I drive back on Tuesdays. I listened to a recording that I did with Wynton Kelly, Jimmy Cobb and Hank Mobley. This was at the then Famous Ballroom in Baltimore. You would play from four until eight, it was sort of a matinee kind of thing, in a large ballroom with many people from all around the Baltimore world would bring their families and have a good time you know. But man, I could not be more proud of myself, the way I was swinging with Wynton Kelly and Jimmy Cobb and in re Paul Chambers, who wasn't available at the time and I was selected to replace him. You know, my greatest hero on the instrument, I was sort of taking his place. And the reason why I loved Paul Chambers is that his tone was so well-rounded, well-chosen, and, you know, the application of that tone on the beat was unlike anybody else insofar as swing is concerned. I mean you know Ray Brown was over there, and so forth, my history. Paul Chambers was, the romance of his tone gets me. And it's like he felt something that produced that tone, perhaps Ray Brown did too. I'm speaking of people that really swung. Right? But Paul Chambers had, the way his tones would not only be placed but would be received by another tone and so forth, and so forth. His choices of giving various tones responsibilities, you know, unlike anybody else that really, really inspired me. So I'm listening to myself with Wynton Kelly and Jimmy Cobb. And these guys are the guys that were with Paul Chambers throughout Miles's,

Cobb and Wynton Kelly because of my inspiration — I'm sounding almost just like Paul. But when it came to soloing I wasn't really too comfortable with that because I was still working on various techniques to improve even upon what Paul was doing. See when, in the Army, I decided to add this finger to my pizzicato adventures. You know? Usually you can play with one finger, for better technique two fingers, for me I decided to use a third. And when in the Army, during all that practice, I worked on that. So when I was with these guys that was still developing. So my solos were not really to my liking. So yesterday I just went and turned it off. 53 years ago.

MR: It reminds me, I recently was talking to a younger bass player and we were talking about bass solos and he expressed that he would get quite aggravated when it was time for the bass solo and everybody else just stopped. You know like okay, a cappella, it's all on you and there's no accompaniment and no support. And I wonder when you have your choice what do you like to have happen behind your bass solo?

CM: Behind my bass solo — well first of all, if in tempo, the piano must sustain chords to support me. Don't rhythmatize anything. Don't play rhythmically you know. Just sustain, so I can have a carpet, I can hear where the changes are going. But other than that, it's important to be able to express regardless of the situation. Like Elvin Jones used to tell me, he says, "McBee, if you don't hear anything, if you don't have anything to play, if you don't feel nothing," he says, "play that."

MR: Can you say that again?

CM: He says, "If you're soloing and you don't feel like playing something, if you don't feel comfortable with what you're playing, play that." Which means that given those special moments of practice, of study, that will come in, that vibe, that feeling of intent to be excellent will manifest itself somehow, even in the spirit of, you know — I tell my students, important is to after you play something if you don't hear that, stop and look where you're going because when you do that, stop. The spirit of it all of who you are will manifest and point the way for you. Right? In terms of how it feels. So but I'm reminded in Paris there's a club called the New Morning Jazz Club. Maybe 150, 200 people sat in the place. I was with the leaders at the time and we were going to, after the concert, celebrate Kirk Lightsey's birthday, he's on piano. And so we're performing a tune by Arthur Blythe that I couldn't find anything ever to do with that tune because it was well with respected to Arthur, I did not like the tune. It was like C-C-C-C-Dflat-D-E-E-E-B-B-E-E-C forever. Right. Great melody but harmonically a little under. So I never soloed on it. So, and I guess the guys in the band knew that. So here we are, we've concluded all the solos and usually Don Moye would take a drum solo, right? And we'd walk away and let him do his thing. So at the conclusion of the piano solo I look up and

know. And I said what the hell do I do? Here's something I don't like, I'm uncomfortable, and the people are like expecting the adventure of Cecil McBee. And what I did, I closed my eyes, literally, I just closed my eyes and went into my living room to where I usually would practice, and I played that. I put the tempo down and just played an open solo as though I would practice, and I ventured into this area and that area, and then I would balk a little bit, which would lead me into this you know, I really improvised. And it turned out rather well. So that was a trying moment for me in the eyes of the world in terms of who I really was, to make something happen out of nothing so to speak.

MR: You seem to place quite a bit of emphasis on who you are, presenting the music, I'm trying to form this question. The music reflects who you are. Is that a basic tenet of your philosophy?

CM: Yeah. Because I never was one who was very expressive with words. In coming up I did not have a reasonable, any reasonable success in high school. I never read a lot. There were conditions, social conditions, that were rather distracting you know, but all the way upon entering college etcetera, etcetera, my desire was to discover more and more who I was in terms of what I had not been as a person that would express himself verbally. So I chose the instrument and I chose music as a vehicle that would allow me, or give me the opportunity to speak in terms of, to speak, so to speak, to say what I couldn't say intrinsically. The music expressed who I was and so forth, and how I felt about things. Now if you want to talk about my mindset afterwards then I could better speak about who I was and what my intention was.

MR: Nice. You were talking, we were talking about Paul Chambers and you used the word "responsibility of his notes." I've always felt for a long time that the bass in jazz has the most responsibility of any instrument in the group.

CM: Absolutely.

MR: Well I'm glad you agree with me. It seems to me that because you can control the feel and the harmony, you can really direct the music. I guess that's my statement. I wonder how you feel about that?

CM: Excuse me, that's exactly what it is. I've got three young bass players that I'm teaching now and my profession entirely, given their youth, their time of development, is how, is number one how you fashion your quarter note. Your quarter note should be, once chosen, should be realized, that once it's placed on the beat it should be exact, followed by another exact tone, given the quality of the rhythm at the time. You are the timekeeper. You're the conductor. You are the vibe of the entire group. If that quarter note, those series of quarter notes are not placed well in succession then number one the

young man now who is, I told him the other day I said, "Look you're 19 years of age, at my time you're way more advanced than me." I mean this young man is like on the level of Scotty LaFaro, that kind of thing. But he had — he has until recently maintained a bit of confusion about his performances because he had no understanding of how to swing. You know? So I told him, I said, "Look, Scotty LaFaro was one of the greatest legends of all time but you could rarely find him swinging and playing a series of tones that would respect a qualitative beat. Right? He never said one-two-three-four. Rarely did that happen." And I said, "You, if you maintain your study regarding what to do with that, that means you are a complete bassist so long as you understand every tone on the fingerboard that would manifest your quality of beat, either soloistically or walking. So it's like Paul Chambers, when that beat hit the floor it was like round and firm and said, "This is B flat and I'm going to see the next, in a timely fashion I'm going to — I will arrive at the next song in a timely fashion, and the next song, being conscious or intrinsically realized that you are really just playing one-one-one-one-one-one successive situation, maintaining the clock so that the rhythm section, especially the pianist and the drummer, who are hearing that are confident in what they are doing and they can just, you know, whatever they would desire to create and to fashion in their expression they can feel comfortable because of the placement of that tone. That tone should always be exact for the most part. Now once you've developed the exactness of the understanding of how to place that tone then you can loosen up, because you feel that and then you can do other things, see? Once you set a divide then you can open up and be more yourself and more creative at the outer areas of your responsibility.

MR: Wow. I once had the pleasure of hearing in a New York club Louis Hayes —

CM: Ah, Louis Hayes, yes.

MR: I'm telling you, you know you talk about playing on the top side of the beat or on the back side, well to my ears he was so on the top side of the beat that I couldn't figure out how is the music not speeding up? But it wasn't. Then I thought like does the bass player like that? Does the bass player enjoy playing with a drummer who, to my ears, was really pushing the tempo.

CM: He was a little ahead of the beat you're saying?

MR: Yes.

CM: It felt like that to you.

MR: Yeah.

CM: Well after having graduated from college — well when in the Army I met Kirk Lightsey, who was from Detroit, pianist, who convinced me that I should come to Detroit after college, which is what I did. So I entered the world of Paul Chambers, of Ron Carter, of

MR: Louis Hayes.

CM: Louis Hayes. I was sort of a, until now, an adopted son of Detroit, because people seem to have liked what I did. And so I got a chance to play with everybody. And you learn that, you know, at that particular time Detroit was the place where most of the great musicians, you know, came from, you know, Barry Harris, and — there was a vibe there, there was a lady whose name was Alice McLeod. She would have jam sessions at her big Victorian home every Sunday, which I would, you know, participate in occasionally. Everybody that was in town would come to her house and have a good time and just play. So I got a chance to play with a lot of drummers out of Detroit, and I discovered, which helped me — their approach to the beat was just rather, you know if you think about all these great musicians out of Detroit, the beat was just a little — they were a bit more aggressive toward that beat, on that beat, intent to present, I guess, it was a quality of feeling that was so exciting to play the music that you were at the edge of your chair. You know you just, the beat was just a little in advance of itself, which really caused a swing that was amazing and as a bassist you would have to realize that, which is what gave me reason to feel comfortable when I arrived in New York City after coming from Detroit and playing with these great people. So they were always on the edge. And the bass player, maybe it was because you have Ron Carter and Paul Chambers, who produced that kind of excitement collaboratively. And so the only drummer that I experienced that was at that level of anticipation of the beat was Tony Williams. See? I mean there's always, as a bass player regardless of who you were — oh, wait a minute, Jimmy Cobb.

MR: Really?

CM: Yeah. Jimmy Cobb. I'll tell you to this day, I mean I played with all of the drummers but Jimmy Cobb, man I mean this is the funniest son of a gun that ever — he's always on the top of that beat and when I was with them during that performance in Baltimore, as young as I was, he just brought me along, right? And made me realize that I could play swing kind of like Paul Chambers. So out of Detroit there was this slight anticipation of the beat that wasn't realized around the world, which I fashioned a quality of respect for Detroit musicians.

MR: I see.

CM: I mean things really swung you know, and Roy Brooks, who was with Horace Silver for a while, was one of those drummers like that.

MR: Well that's really fascinating. I'm going to jump ahead a little bit and I'm going to play name this Cecil McBee bass line.

CM: Uh oh.

MR: Uh oh. I have a little keyboard here so I'll make an attempt at it.

CM: Well that bass line, there's a tingling in my brain. It reminds me of something. Was that Alice Coltrane?

MR: That's correct. I'm not sure I can pronounce the title correctly, "Journey to Satchidananda."

CM: "Journey in Satchidananda"?

MR: Yes, in, that's right.

CM: Yes. So your question is?

MR: Well my question is, moving from placing quarter notes and swing and playing on top of the beat, this was a totally different task for you it seems like, playing a bass line repetitively in some cases basically the similar thing all the way through, while other players did their explorations. Like you were the anchor. And I wonder if you enjoyed that role, for sometimes the songs could go on for eight or nine minutes. How do you keep your concentration?

CM: You don't concentrate, you just feel it. Something like that, by that I mean it's just a vibe. You are now as a bassist, you are now being rather responsible to maintain the bass line that would support all that is happening beyond you melodically, harmonically, etcetera, etcetera. It was something, quite frankly, that I was already sort of familiar with. Number one my second group — my first group that I performed with in New York City was with Jackie McLean. He trained Bobby Hutcherson, Charles Tolliver, and let me see, and myself. Yeah. But there was a recording that we did, my first, my second recording in New York City was with Jackie McLean called "That's That." And on that record there was a D minor tune that called for you to just swing in D minor, one sound, which really caught my attention because I knew not how to fashion my quarter notes, you know, being placed at the right tempo at the right time, with the choices of various intervals and tones that would, and movement, that would not only keep the beat but, you know, provide various colorations in support of the enclave. I had no idea what that was. So I struggled during that recording. And I guess being a pretty decent music student at school I managed to play something that was reasonably accepted in D minor, right? But the very next year I joined the Charles Lloyd Quartet. And we did, we recorded "Live at Monterey" in Monterey California, a tune called "Sunrise, Sunset" where I play [scats]. In C minor. And that went on forever, the whole half of the [inaudible]. So keeping time like that I was sort of used to that when I, when I played eventually played with Alice Coltrane. But what I'm thinking is it wasn't me that created that bass line. Alice Coltrane showed me that bass line. "This is what I want you to play." So I was kind of comfortable with it after having made the two, mainly the one with Charles Lloyd.

MR: This is sort of a personal question, do you feel you are a spiritual man? Does faith play a

CM: Absolutely.

MR: So when you played with Alice Coltrane and Pharoah Sanders did you feel comfortable with the intent, the seeming intent of the music?

CM: By intent what do you —

MR: Well I'm not sure what I mean and I'm glad you asked that. It seems that the music had a reason for being other than just we have, you know we got a recording date, different from perhaps when a bop musician would get a date and they would get six or seven tunes together, some that they had written and some standards, where the music that you were involved in in the 60s seemed to have another level to it, that there was an intent to affect people as they listened.

CM: Yes. That quality of expression for me began with the Charles Lloyd Quartet. It actually began, we were, I remember during our first performance in Antibes France, this is Jack DeJohnette, Keith Jarrett, myself and Charles Lloyd. We followed, we were fortunate to follow Duke Ellington featuring Ella Fitzgerald in Southern France right at the edge of the Mediterranean with maybe 3- 4,000 people seated outside sort of in an ampitheatrical set up there. We followed Duke Ellington featuring Ella Fitzgerald with the collective feeling that we've heard that. You know, we kind of discussed that in the dressing room but as they say, we wanted to get out and play, this was our first time in Europe playing, come on, let's go, you're playing too long. Now that we are on the stage the music was so exciting insofar as how we were feeling, the confidence in each other to express what we had experienced previous to our arrival in Europe. It was absolutely amazing. We felt so energized and so exciting about how we were feeling individually and collectively that would affect, that would seem to affect the audience. The audience were really very excited about our performance. So the performance, with the performance having been so successful, our next concert, which was at the Golden Circle in Sweden, was just overflowed by people that followed us from Southern France to that club to hear us, you know, we were excited to know that upon stepping on the stage people would just really demonstrate great excitement to see us walk on the concert stage, not only into the stage not only just to play. So we realized, personally I realized that we were expressing something that was rather intrinsical, because if you think of Keith Jarrett and Jack DeJohnette and myself, we all were people that felt something when we played. And here were three people — along with four people — along with Charles Lloyd that played music that had a quality of spirit with it. Matter of fact Heikki Sarmanto, a Finnish pianist that I met during that tour, we are good friends to today and he helps me out a lot about how the people felt who we were, you know. We weren't just playing tunes we were feeling something. And so as I said before, I'm one who is intent to express when I play

would sometimes come from a place that I don't even know about. When I was a young man of course there was the church and there was the community where you heard music that made you, that called your attention to persons or groups that were feeling something. So the Charles Lloyd group was one that prepared me for that Alice Coltrane recording, because that "Journey in Satchidananda" meant that she was going there to pray, to respect the gods of her choice, you know, so far as being her continued existence musically and personally. So I think over the years I've gotten a lot of fine comments about how I play, you just mentioned on that record, and it was about something that I felt. And to this day that's who I am. When I play my instrument I'm very privileged to be quiet and play a couple of notes and I'm just fine.

MR: Oh well said.

CM: In fact every morning before I have breakfast I test my instrument and make sure it tells me who I am that day.

MR: Wonderful. I believe, I know I saw you in Rochester, New York with the Charles Lloyd group —

CM: Oh you saw that group then?

MR: Yes I did, and it did have a certain — it's so interesting how some undefinable magic created by four people is felt by a lot of people. And that it becomes an event.

CM: Yeah. In all honesty that was one of the greatest, most precious moments of my career playing with those guys. They were just — there was a spirit in the group that to this day is relatively unsurpassed this side of Pharoah Sanders who played a lot of spiritual music. But the Charles Lloyd situation was more not only individually collected, you know, spirits that felt something, but there was a quality of intellect that would fashion these things that would come about musically on the stage. And I just heard the other day that Keith Jarrett is ill. Have you heard that?

MR: Yes. I think he's had a stroke and probably won't be playing again is what he expressed.

CM: I almost broke down and cried because I've looked forward to play with this guy again, in memory of what we had attained. And so it brought back all of those memories about who we were. And so I say a prayer for him.

MR: Yeah. Let me ask you a question about when you have recorded as a leader, I wonder if you've ever had a situation where you needed to tell someone in the group to play differently, or not do something, because you collectively write compositions and we have something in our head, and then we hand the parts out to other people, we teach them, and you're not sure what you're going to get. So if I go back to my original question, have you ever had to re-direct someone on a recording because you weren't quite happy with what they were doing?

CM: Sure. Remember you, as a composer, you are the one that has exacted qualities of thought that find, you know, qualities of performances by those that you have chosen. So simply you can ask someone to, like I said before, when I play, when I'm soloing, please sustain the chords. Don't get rhythmic, don't get rhythmic because that might interfere with my rhythms when I'm soloing. So if you know, anything can be altered. During a recording things are constantly done, adjusted from time to time. You might want your alto to play an octave lower, or play an octave higher. But then you might want him to play in the middle of the piano. You might want the drums to use brushes etcetera. So there are a lot of adjustments that are made in the studio that would help fashion the final recording, adjustments that would ordinarily be made spontaneously on the stage. At the end of the set you might tell the piano look, why don't you lay out at that spot and I can have that spot fashion more of what I'm doing rhythmically doing on the bass, then you might enter at Letter B or something. So those things happen all the time.

MR: Yeah. On a personal note I was happy to see that a musician that was a housemate of mine at SUNY Fredonia played on your record, Onaje Allan Gumbs.

CM: Oh what's that, "Mutima?"

MR: "Mutima" yes.

CM: Oh my very first recording.

MR: Yes.

CM: That was a rather exciting moment because actually I failed to mention to you that upon arrival in New York City I felt that I was more a composer than a performer. Because in college I mean upon arriving at school I had never played the piano before. I didn't even know what that was as far as putting my fingers on the keyboard and making something happen. But as a potential music instructor the piano was the first assignment of study. So I fell in love with that and began, you know, exploring, and especially with the understanding that the great Frank Foster who was a previous graduate of my school which is Central State University in Southwest Ohio. He had — his big band had won the national big band contest for quality performance, which brought a bit of acclaim to that little school in Southwest Ohio.

MR: Nice.

CM: So upon hearing some of my little tunes that I had begun to create, the students chose me as, you know, one that might want to resurrect the Centrillions, the band that Frank Foster left, and so we brought out, we were give his compositions and we played a few concerts around, and my conducting. So I found a thrill to discover things on the piano that might give me reason to express myself in that medium. So I spent a lot of time on the piano getting my chord changes and I began to write tunes. So when I first arrived in New York

first composition that I wrote upon arriving in New York City that first year was a tune called "Song of Her."

MR: Which was on the Forest Flower record is that correct?

CM: My very first recording.

MR: Nice.

CM: Right? And so I was more excited about having my tune on the recording rather than what it really meant. You know I called my mother and said, "Mom, you know, they recorded my music." And to this day it's supposed to be one of my most appreciated tunes. But so throughout, until now, have always sat at the piano and I've collected a lot of music. So when "Mutima" came about this was the opportunity for me to demonstrate to the world at large that I was a composer not just a bass player. I had a chance to realize on the recording to the public that there were other levels of thought compositionally that I felt pretty good about.

MR: I watched that lovely video of you for your 84th birthday and there were some great quotes in there, one of which was when I feel something I run to the piano, something like that. Yeah. I also loved that moment, I had to laugh because there was a moment where you were rehearsing a group with those three wonderful saxophone players and one of them was working on his part and he kept playing this interval and apparently it was wrong. And you said something like, "Now I know why I shouldn't have jumped out of bed and wrote this" or something.

CM: I was being very gentle at the time, my disposition. I'm going to fathom getting beat up.

MR: Was there a series of years being in New York that were the most difficult to actually make a living because of either where jazz was at or economic times? Was it ever a struggle during a particular number of years?

CM: No. To be blunt about it, to this day I've been very fortunate to maintain what gives me reason to relate to my students about how to maintain in terms of being prepared for the event on the stage. I preach occupation to so speak. I mean survival insofar as economics are the ability to maintain financially on the stage as one who has just entered the world of performance, I try to prepare one to be at a level of respect that would create a possibility of finding employment or continuous activity, whatever. But there was one moment that the spirits of the music taught me a lesson. It was one moment in '67 before I met Alice Coltrane. At the time I was much hipper than I am now. I was rather the word causative comes to mind, a young man. I was dressed very well, you wore sort of thin pants, bell bottom pants. And there was a watch pocket here. I had three twenty dollar bills that I put in there, to my name, I put in this watch pocket in these pants that fit so tight that it was almost like — you know, I mean it just hugged your skin. When I got to

bills had fallen out of my pocket. I had no savings, no nothing. That's when it hit me. Because there were no performances in the near future. So I went through a bit, about three months of uncertainty. After about a couple of weeks I began borrowing from friends to get a little of this and that. And then after about a month there was no, I mean nobody would support me. Even my best friends. So I struggled for about two months without anything, just, I don't know how I did that but I had no money at all until a gig came, a concert came with — who was I with, that was with Yusef Lateef. And so I learned that you should always stay ahead of yourself. If you earn three hundred dollars, two hundred are not yours, only one. And you put the rest away.

MR: Nice.

CM: But that was a telling moment.

MR: Life lessons, yeah. How do you pass that on — I'm going to rephrase — when you have a really talented student like you've mentioned a couple of them, do you ever unexpectedly say, "All right, play 'Stardust' because someday you're going to have to play 'Stardust'" and you're going to want to be able to do it. Do you ever get to that sort of practical level with them?

CM: No, I'm sorry I don't do that. What I do, I help — even — I don't teach, the bass is not the only instrument that I teach. I teach general improvisation, techniques and theories and harmonies. And what I do is I have — I think I might have the biggest collection of tunes of anybody given my time and my age, in the wide world. I've got all of the standard tunes, most individual tunes of various respective composers I have of all levels of thought for the most part. I have a vast body of information on paper that I present to my students given the moment that will prepare them for eventuality. Certain tunes will, with me staying doing my best to maintain a step or two ahead of the students, certain tunes will inspire them to fashion qualities of approach such as, you know, rhythmic development, harmonic development, etcetera, etcetera. And so I figure if you study, if you would involve yourself at various levels of performance during your study periods you should be able to handle anything outside. In other words I prepare you for the moment, you know, with the understanding that most of the tunes that I have are challenging enough to familiarize yourself with possibilities past the moment that would, as I said earlier, that would help you get on the stage. I would not require you to learn — well "'Round Midnight," you know, "Oleo," during our practice or study we might play those, right? To get you familiar with those kinds of tunes. But overall you will have experienced all qualities of performances that will prepare you for the unexpected on the stage. That's what I'm trying to say.

MR: Wonderful.

CM: So my bass students, they are given the techniques of theory and harmony and also swinging, you know, maintaining the quality of the tone, etcetera, etcetera, as far as its responsibilities to arrive and depart from situations harmonically and rhythmically. If you would submit to them a quality of a tune they would be able to go right through that and understand what it is regardless of the date.

MR: Sounds wonderful. So we've been talking for over an hour. I wonder if we might do a revisit soon, because I'm surrounded by my notes here, which I hardly got to any of it, although I've so much enjoyed this conversation.

CM: I'm just out of bed — I'm just beginning to wake up now.

MR: Okay, well maybe on part two we'll go at like 4 P.M. or something like that.

CM: Yeah, I would like that. I find this very pleasant and there's a lot more that I feel I might be able to verbally get out of myself.

MR: Great. So I'm just going to pause our recording here, and we'll make a date to meet again.

CM: Okay. All right.